

SFPA Spring 2026 City Championship

Title Odds — Tournament Projection

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Rawhides are the favorite to win the City Championship at **80%**, ahead of a tight chase between **Bus Stop** (15%) and **El Farolito** (3%). Together the top three hold about 97% of all title equity; below them the field falls off sharply.

Team	Seed	Title %	Reach Grand Final
Happy Lounge Rawhides	1	79.5%	93%
Bus Stop Flyers	3	15.0%	60%
El Farolito Shooters	2	2.6%	18%
Hall Monitors	4	1.6%	13%
Marcelo's Hall Stars	8	1.2%	13%
Pocket Full of Fizz	7	0.1%	2%
Happy HALLers	5	0.0%	0%
Pilsner InnDecisives	6	0.0%	0%
Gino & Carlo	9	0.0%	0%
Lucky Horseshoe Glue Factory	10	0.0%	0%
Friends Crooked Cues	11	0.0%	0%
Route 101 Dalmatians	12	0.0%	0%
Karl's Freakin' Beacon	13	0.0%	0%
Temple Holy Smokes	14	0.0%	0%
Bus Slop	15	0.0%	0%
Lower Haight Misfits	16	0.0%	0%

Last Week: Winners' Bracket Semifinals + Losers' Bracket R3

Start with the favorite. A week ago the model gave Rawhides 64.7% to win the City Championship; tonight that number jumped to 79.5% — a 14.8-point rise and another sharp move up. The daylight behind them is becoming a canyon.

They got there by booking the winners'-bracket final: Rawhides beat Hall Monitors 9-7 and Bus Stop beat Pocket Fizz 9-7. The A-side title match is set — Rawhides vs Bus Stop — and it carries a double-elimination twist: the winner walks into the grand final with a safety net (the losers'-bracket survivor has to beat them twice), while the loser is knocked to the one-loss side. Bus Stop climbed to 15% as the second-most-likely champion — distant, but real.

The night's gut-punch landed on the losers' side — and it was the end of an era. El Farolito ended Pilsner's season 9-6, and with it one of the great runs in City Championship history. For six-plus seasons the InnDecisives never fell out of the top two; their all-time playoff record is 17-7, and the number that defined the dynasty is 15-0 — their mark against everyone who wasn't the Rawhides. For years you did not beat Pilsner. Rawhides beat Pilsner, and nobody else got a turn.

This was supposed to be the redemption year. Evan Burgess, their 576-rated ace, had spent the first half of the season playing down with a junior team as its coach — he was always coming back for the playoffs, and it was his absence from the standings, not from the roster, that stuck a team this good with the 6-seed. He returned, the lineup was whole, and for a while the old magic held. But here is the cruelest detail: for the first time anyone can remember, Pilsner's season didn't end against Rawhides. They fell one rung short of even reaching the rival the whole bracket was bending toward. Six seasons of inevitability, gone quietly in the one-loss bracket. Pour one out for the InnDecisives.

There was a Cinderella in the wreckage, too, and midnight finally came: Marcelo's ended Route 101's run 9-2. But what a run it was. The 12th-seed Dalmatians knocked off a top seed in the opening round and then flat refused to lose a close one — both of their wins were 9-8 heart-stoppers that made the smart money sweat for weeks. The glass slipper doesn't fit anymore, but the Dalmatians danced a lot longer than a 12th seed has any right to.

Hall Monitors and Pocket Fizz survive but drop to the losers' bracket, where one more slip ends it. 6 teams remain. For Rawhides, only the winners'-bracket final stands between them and the grand final.

Result	Model predicted	Actual
(1) Rawhides def. (4) Hall Monitors	Rawhides 9-7	9-7
(3) Bus Stop def. (7) Pocket Fizz	Bus Stop 9-7	9-7
(2) El Farolito def. (6) Pilsner — beat the pick	Pilsner 9-8	9-6
(8) Marcelo's def. (12) Route 101	Marcelo's 9-5	9-2

Model-predicted score (favorite and expected margin) vs. the actual result. Shaded rows mark a match the model's pick lost; winner's game count shown first.

Looking Ahead

The hot seat — Rawhides vs Bus Stop

The one everybody's tuning in for. The winners'-bracket final decides who takes the hot seat: a ticket straight to the grand final with the double-elimination cushion that makes a team nearly impossible to dislodge. The loser doesn't go home, but drops to the one-loss side and inherits the long gauntlet back. Win here and you're most of the way to a title; lose and the mountain triples.

And these two have history. Over the last four seasons plus this year's regular season, Rawhides and Bus Stop have met 6 times — and Rawhides have won 5 of them, taking 63% of all the games played between the two clubs. Bus Stop's lone win came on a regular-season night; when the playoff lights come on it hasn't been close, with Rawhides a perfect 2-0 in the postseason and 75% of those games (18-6).

On Fargo alone the model makes Rawhides a 75% pick for the match (a 58% edge per game). Layer in the head-to-head — the fact that Bus Stop has never solved this specific opponent when it mattered — and the number climbs toward 85%. Ratings and receipts point the same way. Bus Stop's path to the upset is real but narrow: they've hung big game counts on Rawhides before, so the talent to make it a match is there — they just have to finally close one on the big stage.

Win or go home — El Farolito vs Hall Monitors

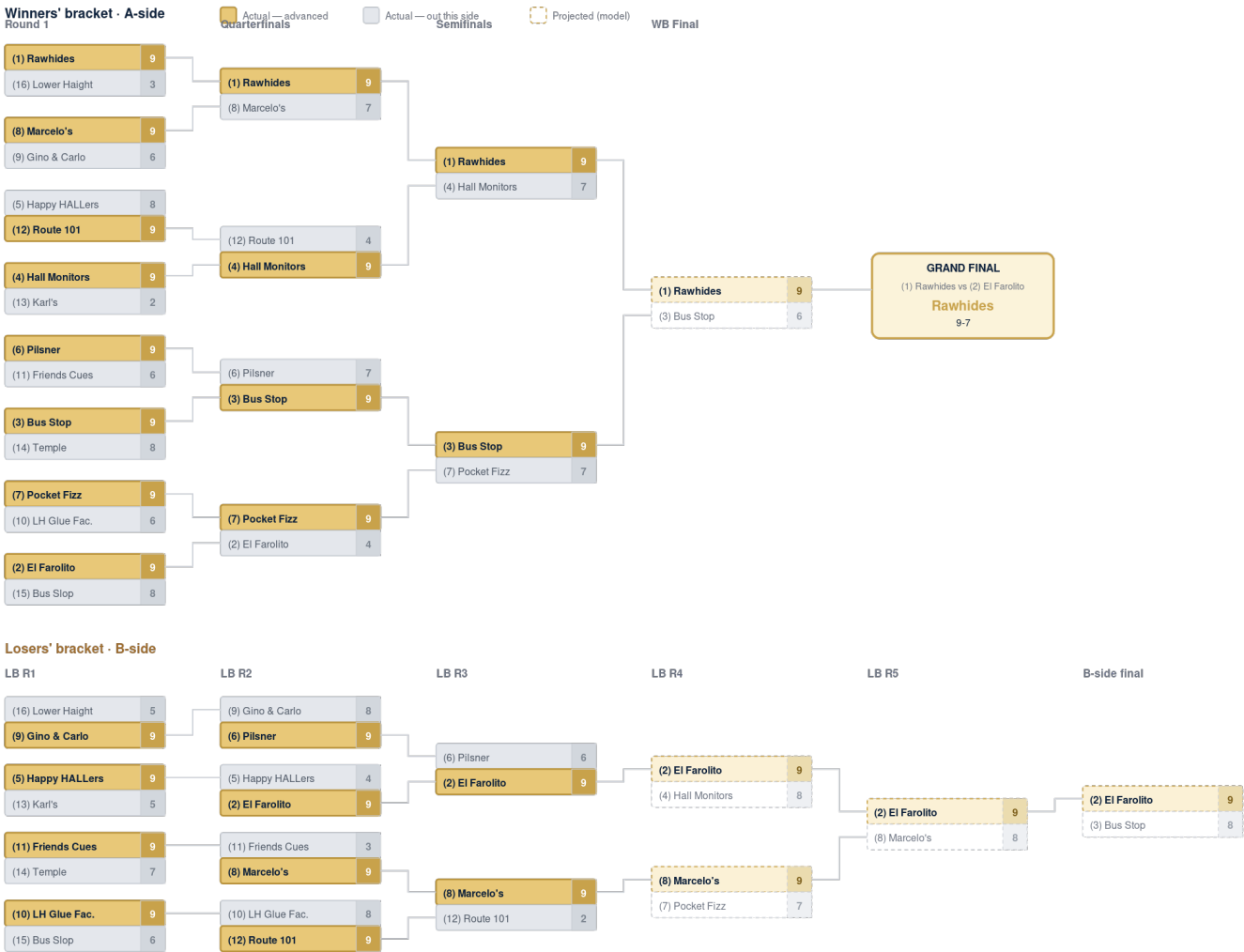
The sleeper heavyweight bout of the round. El Farolito (the 2-seed and the field's hottest regular-season form team) and Hall Monitors (the 4-seed with one of the deepest lineups in the draw) are two of the best teams left in the whole draw — and because each stumbled once on the A-side, they're colliding this early with a season on the line. It's the closest match on the board: the model splits it 54%–46%, effective Fargos of 569 and 561 just points apart. Both teams already carry a loss, so this one is simple: the winner plays on, the loser's playoff is over. Two contenders, a near-even matchup, sudden death — if you watch one losers'-bracket match, make it this one.

Win or go home — Marcelo's vs Pocket Fizz

A quieter but no-less-tense elimination game. Marcelo's (the 8-seed quietly on a roll) meet Pocket Fizz (the 7-seed that stunned El Farolito in the quarterfinals), and the model gives Marcelo's the edge, but Pocket Fizz are live — 68% for the match on a 56% per-game advantage (effective Fargo 553 to 521). Both teams already carry a loss, so this one is simple: the winner plays on, the loser's playoff is over. But seeds have already meant little in this bracket, and one hot night flips it.

Projected Bracket

Single most-likely path through the 16-team double elimination. Lose on the A-side (winners') and you drop to the B-side (losers"); a second loss ends your run. The B-side survivor must beat the A-side finalist twice. **Grand Final:** (1) Rawhides vs (2) El Farolito — champion **Rawhides** (9-7).



Playoff Standouts

The bracket is a team game, but somebody has to make the balls. A look at who's carrying the load for the teams still standing — the players quietly (and not so quietly) winning their matches within the match.

Standout of the round

No one has been better with the season on the line. Steven Waldon has gone **7-1** in the playoffs — a **88%** win rate, the best of any regular still standing — and this week he went **4-0 with a table run**, closing out the winners'-bracket semifinal himself with the deciding rack over Hall Monitors' Clancy Green to send Rawhides to the final. That's the Waldon pattern: he ran the table a league-leading count of times this season, and his playoff table-run consistency is the stuff of local legend. If the grand final ever comes down to a single deciding game, he's exactly who the Rawhides want stepping to the table.

Player	Team	Playoff W-L	Win %	Table runs
Steven Waldon	Rawhides	7-1	88%	1
Albert Yip	Pocket Fizz	6-1	86%	—
Prithiv Kumar	Hall Monitors	9-2	82%	1
Antonio Cracchiolo	Hall Monitors	8-2	80%	—
Khanh Ngo	Marcelo's	8-2	80%	1
Wade Hargrove	Bus Stop	6-2	75%	—
Willie Gregory	Marcelo's	5-2	71%	—
Tom Purcell	Bus Stop	8-4	67%	—

Individual game record across the playoff weeks, for players on teams still alive (min. 6 games). Table runs = racks won from the break without the opponent reaching the table.

Hottest hands this week: **Steven Waldon** (Rawhides) 4-0 [table run]; **Perez Vallarta** (El Farolito) 4-0 [table run]; **Khanh Ngo** (Marcelo's) 3-0; **Nithin Tharakan** (Marcelo's) 3-0.

Playoff Performance Ratings

A performance rating answers a different question than a win-loss record: *how good did you actually play?* We take every individual game a player played this playoff run, look up each opponent's Fargo, and solve for the rating at which their win total is exactly what you'd expect. Beat a 500-rated player at a 4-2 clip and you performed like a 600. It rewards beating strong opponents and doesn't punish anyone for a tough draw — the ultimate opponent-adjusted scoreboard.

Top performer — 833

And nobody in the tournament has played at a higher level than **Steven Waldon**. Against playoff competition averaging **549** Fargo, his 7-1 run computes to an **833 performance rating** — a staggering **+229 over his own 604 rating**, and the single highest performance mark of anyone in the field (the next-best is 743). Put plainly: a very good 604-rated player spent the playoffs playing like an elite 800+. That's not a hot streak against soft competition — his opponents averaged 549 — it's the best pool anyone in this City Championship has played.

Player	Team	W-L	Avg opp	Fargo	Performance	vs rating
Steven Waldon	Rawhides	7-1	549	604	833	+229
Albert Yip	Pocket Fizz	6-1	468	487	743	+256
Khanh Ngo	Marcelo's	8-2	521	583	730	+147
Prithiv Kumar	Hall Monitors	9-2	487	544	719	+175
Antonio Cracchiolo	Hall Monitors	8-2	492	578	707	+129
Wade Hargrove	Bus Stop	6-2	508	552	677	+125
Willie Gregory	Marcelo's	5-2	478	561	616	+55
Tom Purcell	Bus Stop	8-4	505	515	610	+95
Nithin Tharakan	Marcelo's	9-5	512	525	601	+76
Bob Simon	Rawhides	7-4	505	543	591	+48
Otoniel Jimenez	El Farolito	9-6	490	627	553	-74
Perez Vallarta	El Farolito	7-5	487	537	543	+6

Performance = the Fargo level a player performed at across the playoffs, from opponent-weighted results (players on teams still alive, min. 6 games). "vs rating" is performance minus their own Fargo.

The Storylines

Rawhides are one win from the grand final — and they'd get there with a net

The model gives Rawhides a commanding **80%** to win the whole thing. They've reached the winners'-bracket final, and a win over Bus Stop books a grand-final berth with the double-elimination cushion that makes them so hard to kill: whoever climbs out of the losers' bracket would have to beat them *twice*. Their Fargo and Team Elo (1702) tower over what's left of the field. About the only thing that beats Rawhides now is Rawhides — pool is a game of races, and even a runaway favorite drops a few.

The winners'-bracket final: Rawhides vs Bus Stop

This is the A-side title match, and it's worth more than bragging rights. The winner walks into the grand final needing just one win; the loser is knocked to the one-loss bracket and has to climb back the hard way. Rawhides is the heavy favorite, but Bus Stop (the 3rd seed) has already put away two seeded teams to get here and is a 60% live shot to reach the final.

The comeback bracket: 4 teams, one brutal road

Still alive on the losers' side: El Farolito, Hall Monitors, Marcelo's, and Pocket Fizz. Any of them can still reach the grand final — but the price is steep: win out on the one-loss side, then beat the winners'-bracket champion *twice*. El Farolito is the model's pick to emerge at **18%** to reach the final, the last of the pre-playoff contenders still breathing.

What it would take to deny Rawhides

The math is stark — Rawhides win about 80% of simulations. For anyone else to lift the trophy, the bracket has to break just right: a live underdog out of the winners'-bracket final, or a losers'-bracket team running the table and then toppling the A-side finalist twice. The best of the long shots: Bus Stop at 15%; El Farolito at 3%. Real chances — but long ones.

Dynasty watch: the InnDecisives are out

For six-plus seasons Pilsner never finished outside the top two, going 17-7 in playoff pool and a perfect 15-0 against everyone but the Rawhides. This year the run ended — and, for the first time in memory, it ended against someone other than Rawhides, El Farolito closing the book in the losers' bracket. The throne is empty.

Team Elo — Overall Strength

Each team's strength rating: the Fargo of their best playoff lineup, adjusted for season form, plus a data-tested pedigree where earned. Higher = stronger. This is what drives the title odds.

Rank	Team	Team Elo	Top-4 Fargo	Title %
1	Happy Lounge Rawhides	1702	609.5	79.5%
2	Pilsner InnDecisives	1632	539.0	0.0%
3	Hall Monitors	1620	567.0	1.6%
4	El Farolito Shooters	1605	548.0	2.6%
5	Marcelo's Hall Stars	1598	553.8	1.2%
6	Bus Stop Flyers	1594	550.5	15.0%
7	Pocket Full of Fizz	1526	515.0	0.1%
8	Happy HALLers	1509	503.8	0.0%
9	Temple Holy Smokes	1508	513.2	0.0%
10	Gino & Carlo	1502	505.2	0.0%
11	Friends Crooked Cues	1454	478.0	0.0%
12	Route 101 Dalmatians	1412	455.8	0.0%
13	Lucky Horseshoe Glue Factory	1401	453.8	0.0%
14	Bus Slop	1378	443.2	0.0%
15	Karl's Freakin' Beacon	1363	431.8	0.0%
16	Lower Haight Misfits	1317	409.8	0.0%

How These Numbers Were Built

1. A rating based on who actually plays. Each team is rated by its players' Fargo (skill) ratings — but performance is judged against the lineup it *actually fielded* each match, not its best-case roster. If a team rests a star or plays a weaker substitute who performs at their own level, the model doesn't punish them: it expected less, and got it. When a 405-rated depth player loses most of his games to 600-rated opponents, that's neutral, not a black mark. Most rating systems can't tell "played badly" from "fielded a weaker lineup" — this one can, because it reads every individual player's result in every match.

2. Win probabilities — and proof they work. Playoff matches are a race to 9 (a 9-3 match ends after 12 games). The Fargo gap between the two lineups sets each game's odds, capped at 75/25 since pool has too much variance for locks; at 8-8 a single deciding game is played between each team's top player. We back-tested the engine on this season: it correctly called **76.5% of 251 matches** (Brier score 0.154), with well-calibrated confidence — the basis for trusting the odds.

3. 60,000 simulated tournaments. The full double-elimination bracket is played 60,000 times; every number in this report — the title odds and the projected bracket — comes from that one simulation, so they're mutually consistent.

4. A data-tested pedigree for Pilsner. Rather than guess at a "dynasty" weight, we tested it: across four seasons of playoff results, Pilsner's record is 4-season playoff record 17-7 (71%), and every loss came against Rawhides — against everyone else they are a perfect 15-0. That overperformance is statistically real ($p < 0.05$), so Pilsner carries a measured +30 Fargo playoff bump. No other team earned one; Rawhides' four titles are the best team doing what it should, already in its rating.

Every adjustment has a number behind it, not a feel. Pool is high-variance — treat these as probabilities, not predictions; even a clear favorite loses far more often than it wins.

Appendix — Season Form

A supporting metric, not a strength rating: did a team beat or miss its own roster's Fargo expectation this season, match by match? A strong team can show negative form if it underplayed its talent.

Team	Season Form	vs roster
El Farolito Shooters	+28.0	overachieved
Happy HALLers	+17.2	overachieved
Route 101 Dalmatians	+14.4	overachieved
Karl's Freakin' Beacon	+13.9	overachieved
Friends Crooked Cues	+11.6	overachieved
Lower Haight Misfits	+10.8	overachieved
Pocket Full of Fizz	+8.1	overachieved
Pilsner InnDecisives	+4.9	~ as expected
Lucky Horseshoe Glue Factory	+4.0	~ as expected
Bus Stop Flyers	+3.5	~ as expected
Gino & Carlo	+2.4	~ as expected
Bus Slop	+1.6	~ as expected
Marcelo's Hall Stars	+0.1	~ as expected
Hall Monitors	-7.3	underachieved
Happy Lounge Rawhides	-10.4	underachieved

Team	Season Form	vs roster
Temple Holy Smokes	-13.5	underachieved